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Netiquette guidelines

RFC 1855	
Netiquette Guidelines	
Status of This Memo	
This memo provides information for the Internet community. This memo does not specify an Internet standard of any kind. Distribution of this memo is unlimited.	
Abstract	
This document provides a minimum set of guidelines for Network Etiquette (Netiquette) which organisations may take and adapt for their own use. As such, it is deliberately written in a bulleted format to make adaptation easier and to make any particular item easy (or easier) to find. It also functions as a minimum set of guidelines for individuals, both users and administrators. This memo is the product of the Responsible Use of the Network (RUN) Working Group of the IETF.	
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1.0 Introduction	
In the past, the population of people using the Internet had "grown up" with the Internet, were technically minded, and understood the nature of the transport and the protocols. Today, the community of Internet users includes people who are new to the environment. These "Newbies" are unfamiliar with the culture and don't need to know about transport and protocols. In order to bring these new users into the Internet culture quickly, this Guide offers a minimum set of behaviors which organisations and individuals may take and adapt for their own use. Individuals should be aware that no matter who supplies their Internet access, be it an Internet Service Provider through a private account, or a student account at a University, or an account through a corporation, that those organisations have regulations about ownership of mail and files, about what is proper to post or send, and how to present yourself. Be sure to check with the local authority for specific guidelines.	
We've organized this material into three sections: One-to-one communication, which includes mail and talk; One-to-many communications, which includes mailing lists and NewtNews; and Information Services, which includes ftp, WWW, Wais, Gopher, MUDs and MOOs. Finally, we have a Selected Bibliography, which may be used for reference.	
2.0 One-to-One Communication (electronic mail, talk)	
We define one-to-one communications as those in which a person is communicating with another person, as if face-to-face, a dialog. In general, rules of common courtesy for interaction with people should be in force for any situation and on the Internet it's doubly important where, for example, body language and tone of voice must be inferred. For more information on Netiquette for communicating via electronic mail and talk, check references [1,2,25,27] in the Selected Bibliography.	
2.1 User Guidelines	
2.1.1 For mail:	
- Unless you have your own Internet access through an Internet provider, be sure to check with your employer about ownership of electronic mail. Laws about the ownership of electronic mail vary from place to place. - Unless you are using an encryption device (hardware or software), you should assume that mail on the Internet is not secure. Never put in a mail message anything you would not put on a postcard. - Respect the copyright on material that you reproduce. Almost every country has copyright laws. - If you are forwarding or replying to a message you've received, do not change the wording. If the message was a personal message to you and you are replying to a group, you should add permission first. You may shorten the message and quote only relevant parts, but be sure you give proper attribution. - Never send chain letters via electronic mail. Chain letters are forbidden on the Internet. Your network providers will be revoked. Notify your local system administrator if you ever receive one. - A good rule of thumb: Be conservative in what you send and liberal in what you receive. You should not send heated messages (we call these "flames") even if you are provoked. On the other hand, you shouldn't be surprised if you get flamed and it's prudent not to respond to flames. - In general, it's a good idea to at least check all your mail subjects before responding to a message. Sometimes a person who asks you for help (or clarification) will send another message which effectively says "Never mind". Also make sure that any message you respond to was directed to you. You might be cc'd rather than the primary recipient. - Make things easy for the recipient. Many makers strip header information which includes your return address. In order to ensure that people know who you are, be sure to include a line or two at the end of your message with contact information. You can create that file ahead of time and add it to the end of your messages. (Some makers do this automatically.) In Internet parlance, this is known as a ".sig" or "signature" file. Your .sig file takes the place of your business card. (And you can have more than one to apply in	

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